# THE UNKNOWN SIGNAL

*A Fairy Tale by Varun Sai*

*“The world doesn't need perfect words. It needs people willing to understand one another.”*

# Chapter 1: The Sentence That Shouldn't Exist

It began with a keyboard.

Not a magical keyboard. Not an ancient keyboard discovered inside a forgotten temple. Just an ordinary keyboard sitting on the desk of an ordinary young writer named Varun Sai.

At least, that was what Varun believed.

One evening, he sat in front of his computer, trying to write something extraordinary.

The problem was that he had absolutely no idea what to write.

He stared at the blank screen.

Then he began pressing random keys.

"Kjshd fklqwe zmxn..."

He stopped and read the result.

“Wonderful,” he said. “A masterpiece. Nobody will understand it, including me.”

He tried again.

"The moon remembers what the stars forget."

Varun blinked.

He had not intended to write that sentence.

Perhaps his fingers had accidentally pressed the right keys. Perhaps his imagination was playing tricks on him.

He continued typing random letters, watching them form strange combinations.

Then something unusual happened.

The screen went blank.

A small cursor appeared in the centre.

Letters began appearing one by one.

**IF YOU CAN READ THIS, PLEASE ANSWER.**

Varun froze.

He looked at his hands. They were resting beside the keyboard.

He had not typed anything.

He leaned closer to the screen.

“Who wrote that?”

The cursor blinked.

Then another message appeared.

**WE THOUGHT THE OTHER WORLD HAD FORGOTTEN US.**

Varun's heart began beating faster.

He wanted to close the computer, leave the room, and pretend none of this had happened.

Instead, he did the one thing a writer could never resist.

He asked another question.

“Who are you?”

For several seconds, nothing happened.

Then the cursor moved.

```
PLEASE. WE DON'T HAVE MUCH TIME.
```

Outside, the evening sky darkened.

Inside, Varun realised that he was no longer trying to invent a story.

Something was trying to tell him one.

And somehow, it had found him.

# Chapter 2: My Keyboard Has Opinions

Varun stared at the message.

“Okay,” he whispered. “Either I'm dreaming, or my computer has become a very dramatic person.”

The keyboard clicked.

Varun jumped.

Then the screen displayed another message.

```
FIRST, STOP STARING AT ME. IT'S UNCOMFORTABLE.
```

Varun slowly moved his chair backwards.

“YOU CAN TALK?”

```
OBVIOUSLY. YOU'RE READING MY WORDS, AREN'T YOU?
```

“I'm reading words on a screen. That doesn't prove my keyboard can think.”

```
AND YET, HERE WE ARE, HAVING A CONVERSATION.
```

Varun rubbed his eyes.

“Fine. What should I call you?”

The answer appeared immediately.

```
KEYBOARD SAI.
```

“That's a terrible name.”

**IT'S A PROFESSIONAL NAME.**

“Professional? You're a keyboard.”

**AND YOU'RE A WRITER WHO JUST SPENT TEN MINUTES TYPING RANDOM LETTERS. LET'S NOT JUDGE EACH OTHER.**

Varun laughed despite himself.

For the first time that evening, his fear loosened its grip.

“All right, Keyboard Sai. Do you know who sent the first message?”

The keyboard remained silent.

Then the screen changed.

**I DON'T KNOW WHO THEY ARE. BUT I CAN HEAR THEM.**

“Hear them how?”

**THROUGH THE WORDS.**

A new message appeared beneath the first.

**PLEASE ANSWER. THE LIGHT IS FADING.**

Varun leaned forward.

“Whoever you are, I'm here. What do you need?”

The cursor blinked.

Then a name appeared.

**LIORA.**

A second message followed.

```
MY NAME IS LIORA. I LIVE IN ELARION.
```

Varun typed quickly.

“Where is Elarion?”

The reply came slowly, as if the person on the other side were struggling to send it.

```
SOMEWHERE YOUR WORLD CANNOT SEE.
```

Varun glanced at Keyboard Sai.

“That's not a geographical location.”

```
PERHAPS SHE'S NOT USING A MAP.
```

“Could you be serious for five seconds?”

```
I AM BEING SERIOUS. I JUST HAPPEN TO BE FUNNY
WHILE DOING IT.
```

Varun shook his head.

He had always wanted to write a story that would surprise him.

He had never imagined that the story might answer back.

“Liora,” he typed, “I'm listening. Tell me what happened.”

For a moment, the screen filled with flickering symbols.

Then a message appeared.

```
THE TOWER IS DYING. AND WHEN IT GOES DARK, WE
MAY FORGET EVERYTHING.
```

# Chapter 3: A Reply from Nowhere

Varun read the message again.

“The tower is dying,” he murmured. “And you may forget everything.”

He typed, “What tower?”

The reply arrived in fragments.

```
THE TOWER OF FIRST WORDS.

IT CONNECTS OUR WORLD TO THE PATHS BEYOND IT.

IT KEEPS OUR MEMORIES ALIVE.
```

Then the screen flickered.

```
SOMEONE HAS STOPPED LISTENING.
```

Varun felt a chill travel down his back.

“Who?”

There was no answer.

He tried again.

“Liora, who has stopped listening?”

The cursor blinked.

```
I DON'T KNOW HOW MUCH TIME WE HAVE.
```

Varun looked at the clock. Only a few minutes had passed, yet it felt as though he had stepped into a different life.

“Can I help you?”

The keyboard began typing without his fingers touching it.

**MAYBE.**

**YOUR WORLD STILL HAS WORDS. OURS IS LOSING THEM.**

Varun frowned.

“How can words disappear?”

**FIRST, PEOPLE STOP SAYING WHAT THEY THINK. THEN THEY STOP ASKING WHAT OTHERS MEAN. AFTER THAT, THEY FORGET HOW TO LISTEN.**

He read the message carefully.

It sounded less like magic and more like something he had seen in the real world.

People arguing without understanding one another.

Friends hiding their feelings.

Families avoiding difficult conversations.

People pretending to agree because disagreement was uncomfortable.

But how could any of that destroy an entire kingdom?

Varun typed, “What do you want me to do?”

The reply appeared.

**COME TO ELARION.**

Varun stared at the screen.

“Absolutely not.”

**PLEASE.**

“I'm not walking into a computer.”

**YOU WALK INTO STORIES EVERY DAY.**

Varun paused.

That answer was annoyingly reasonable.

The screen filled with a final message.

**IF YOU WANT TO UNDERSTAND US, YOU MUST SEE US.**

Then the monitor went dark.

For several seconds, Varun sat perfectly still.

He could hear the ordinary sounds of his home. A distant voice. A door closing. The quiet hum of electricity.

Everything was normal.

Except his keyboard.

A tiny golden light appeared between two keys.

It grew brighter.

Varun swallowed.

“Keyboard Sai?”

**YES?**

“What happens if I touch it?”

**I WOULD RECOMMEND NOT ASKING ME AFTER YOU'VE ALREADY DONE IT.**

Varun had not touched it yet.

But before he could ask another question, the golden light spread across the desk.

The air shimmered.

And a doorway appeared where the computer screen had been.

Beyond it, a strange sky glittered with unfamiliar stars.

Varun stood up.

He was frightened.

He was curious.

And, against every sensible instinct he possessed, he took a step forward.

# Chapter 4: Welcome to Elarion

The first thing Varun noticed was the sky.

It was filled with colours he had never seen together before. Silver clouds drifted beneath floating islands, and bridges of light connected distant cliffs. Trees glowed softly, their branches carrying tiny points of blue and gold.

Varun stood on a stone platform overlooking a vast valley.

“Either I've discovered another world,” he whispered, “or I really need to sleep more.”

A voice answered from behind him.

“You're in Elarion.”

Varun turned.

A young woman stood near the glowing doorway. She wore a teal cloak marked with delicate silver symbols. Her expression was serious, but her eyes held a cautious hope.

“Liora?”

She nodded.

“You came.”

“You asked me to.”

“I wasn't certain anyone would answer.”

Varun looked around.

“Where exactly are we?”

“Elarion. A world connected to others through paths that most people can no longer see.”

“Why can't they see them?”

“Because the paths are made from more than light. They are made from memories, stories, and the willingness to understand someone different from yourself.”

Varun considered that.

“So the paths are disappearing because people have stopped listening?”

“Not all the paths,” Liora replied. “But enough to frighten us.”

She began walking, and Varun followed.

As they crossed a bridge of light, he saw distant islands floating above a sea of clouds. Strange birds moved through the air, leaving trails of sparkling dust.

It was beautiful.

But something was wrong.

The glowing trees flickered. Some of the bridges had broken into scattered points of light. Far away, a tower stood above the kingdom, its highest windows dim and colourless.

“What happens if the tower goes dark?” Varun asked.

Liora stopped.

“Our memories will begin to disappear. Our stories will be lost. Eventually, we may forget not only our history but also the people we love.”

Varun looked towards the tower.

“Then we need to fix it.”

Liora gave a small, sad smile.

“If it were that simple, we would have done it already.”

They continued towards the city of Auralis.

For the first time, Varun understood that this was not merely a strange adventure.

People were losing something they could never replace.

And he had no idea how to save them.

# Chapter 5: The Kingdom of Forgotten Words

Auralis had once been a city filled with music, conversation, and stories.

Now, its streets felt strangely quiet.

People walked through the markets carrying baskets of glowing fruit and delicate glass objects. They greeted one another politely, but their smiles seemed uncertain.

A woman stood outside a small shop, staring at a young boy.

“I'm sorry,” she said. “I know you. I know I do. But I cannot remember your name.”

The boy lowered his head.

“It's all right,” he replied, though his voice suggested that it was not.

Varun looked at Liora.

“Is this happening everywhere?”

“More often every day.”

They entered a vast library filled with floating books. Their pages turned by themselves, revealing stories that faded whenever someone tried to read them aloud.

At the centre of the library stood an elderly man wearing a long, dark cloak.

His eyes moved from Liora to Varun.

“You brought someone from beyond the paths.”

“This is Varun,” Liora said. “He received our messages.”

The old man studied him.

“Then the signal reached another world after all.”

“Who are you?” Varun asked.

“Eldrin. I was once the Keeper of Signal. My duty was to protect the messages that travelled between worlds.”

“Can you repair the tower?”

Eldrin looked away.

“If only the problem were that simple.”

Liora stepped closer.

“Tell him what is happening.”

Eldrin's expression hardened.

“The kingdom is suffering from a sickness that cannot be cured with medicine. Our words are disappearing because the connections between us are weakening.”

“Why?” Varun asked.

“People stopped trusting one another. They began to fear disagreement. Some decided that certain words were dangerous

and should never be spoken.”

“Words can be dangerous,” Varun replied. “People can use them to hurt others.”

“True,” Eldrin said. “But they can also use silence to hurt others. We forgot the difference between preventing harm and preventing honesty.”

He walked towards a window overlooking the city.

“Our rulers wanted peace. At first, they asked people to be careful with their words. Then they demanded that difficult messages be approved before anyone could share them. Eventually, people stopped saying what they truly thought.”

Liora's face tightened.

“And the tower began to fail.”

Eldrin nodded.

“The tower preserves the connections created when people share memories, ask questions, disagree honestly, and listen. When those connections weakened, its light began to fade.”

Varun thought about the strange messages on his computer.

“Can the tower be saved?”

Eldrin looked towards the distant structure.

“There may be one chance. But to understand it, you must reach the Tower of First Words.”

He hesitated.

“Be careful. Something has formed in the silence we left behind.”

“What something?” Varun asked.

Eldrin did not answer.

Outside, a shadow passed over the library window.

For a moment, every floating book stopped turning.

Then the pages began to fade.

# Chapter 6: The Girl Who Kept the Stories

Liora led Varun through a narrow passage behind the library.

“My grandmother used to say that a story isn't alive because it is written down,” she explained. “It is alive because someone remembers it, shares it, or discovers something new in it.”

She opened a small wooden door.

Inside was a room filled with handwritten pages.

Some were carefully preserved in glass cases. Others were tied together with ribbons. A few lay scattered across a desk, their ink fading at the edges.

“These belonged to my grandmother,” Liora said.

Varun picked up a page.

It described two friends who disagreed about the direction of a journey. Instead of forcing one another to accept a decision, they explained their reasons, listened, and found a third path neither had considered.

“It's a simple story,” he said.

“It is. That's why I kept it.”

“Why?”

“Because the kingdom began throwing away stories that made people uncomfortable. Stories about mistakes. Stories about unfair decisions. Stories in which someone powerful was wrong.”

Liora carefully returned the page to its place.

“My grandmother believed that people did not need to agree about everything. They needed to be willing to understand why someone else believed something different.”

“What happened to her?”

Liora looked down.

“She grew old while the stories around her disappeared. Sometimes, she could remember the stories but not the names of the people in them. Near the end, she forgot some of her own memories.”

Varun didn't know what to say.

Liora continued.

“I promised her I would keep the stories safe. I thought that preserving the pages would be enough.”

She looked around the room.

“But a story locked away cannot help anyone. The words survive, perhaps, but the connection is lost.”

Varun understood then why Liora had contacted another world.

She wasn't merely trying to save a tower.

She was trying to save the things that made her world worth saving.

He placed the page back carefully.

“Then we'll bring the stories back.”

Liora looked at him.

“You cannot promise that.”

“No,” Varun admitted. “But I can promise to try.”

For the first time since he had arrived, Liora smiled without sadness.

“Then let's go.”

They packed several pages into a small satchel and left the library.

Behind them, unnoticed, a thin trail of black letters slipped beneath the door.

The Silence had found their path.

# Chapter 7: The Silence Is Coming

The road to the tower passed through a forest of silver trees.

At first, the forest seemed peaceful. Tiny lights floated between the branches, and the leaves whispered in a language Varun almost understood.

Then the whispers stopped.

The lights disappeared one by one.

Liora suddenly caught Varun's arm.

“Don't move.”

Something was drifting between the trees.

It looked like a cloud of black letters, twisting and shifting without forming any complete words. Fragments of forgotten conversations flickered inside it.

A name.

An apology.

A question.

A promise that had never been kept.

The letters moved closer.

Varun tried to speak.

Nothing came out.

He opened his mouth again, but his voice had vanished.

Liora was struggling too. Her lips moved, yet no sound escaped.

The black letters circled them.

Varun felt a terrible pressure in his mind. It was as though every unfinished conversation he had ever witnessed were pressing against him at once.

The Silence.

He remembered Eldrin's warning.

The creature was not simply darkness. It was everything the kingdom had refused to say, everything its people had refused to hear, and everything they had pretended to understand.

Varun reached for Liora's hand.

She squeezed it tightly.

He forced himself to speak.

“Listen!”

The word came out as a whisper.

The letters stopped moving.

Varun tried again.

“WE'RE LISTENING!”

His voice broke through the strange pressure.

For one brief moment, the black letters became still. A few transformed into tiny points of light.

Then the creature retreated between the trees.

Sound returned to the forest.

Varun fell to his knees, breathing hard.

“What was that?” he asked.

Liora looked towards the place where the creature had vanished.

“The Silence.”

“Can we destroy it?”

“I don't know.”

“Can we stop it?”

Liora was quiet for a moment.

“Perhaps. But I don't think it can be defeated by a sword.”

Varun looked at his hands.

“Then we need to find another way.”

Far beyond the forest, the Tower of First Words stood against the sky.

Its light flickered once.

Then again.

And the darkness began moving towards it.

# Chapter 8: The Tower of First Words

The tower rose above a valley of floating stones.

Its walls were covered in symbols, names, and messages written in languages from countless worlds. Some glowed brightly. Others were so faint that Varun could barely see them.

He recognised a few fragments.

They were the strange sentences that had appeared on his keyboard before Liora's message.

“Those words came from here,” he whispered.

Liora nodded.

“The tower sends messages along the paths between worlds. Sometimes, fragments reach places where they are not expected.”

“That's why I was typing those random sentences?”

“Perhaps the messages were mixing with the words from your own world. We don't understand exactly how it happened. We only know that the connection reached you.”

A sound came from behind them.

Varun turned.

Eldrin stood at the edge of the path, his cloak torn by branches and his face pale with exhaustion.

“You followed us?” Liora asked.

Eldrin lowered his eyes.

“I told myself I was protecting you by staying away. The truth is, I was afraid.”

“Afraid of what?” Varun asked.

“Of what you would discover inside that tower—and what you would think of me afterward.”

Liora looked towards the entrance.

“Whatever the truth is, Eldrin, we cannot change it by running away from it.”

Eldrin nodded slowly and followed them inside.

The tower was silent.

At its centre stood a circular chamber with a crystal suspended above a stone platform. Its light was almost gone.

Messages covered the walls.

Some were written in the language of Elarion. Others belonged to worlds beyond it.

Varun approached a familiar inscription.

```
IF YOU CAN READ THIS, PLEASE ANSWER.
```

Below it was another.

```
WE THOUGHT THE OTHER WORLD HAD FORGOTTEN US.
```

“These were the messages I received,” he said.

Eldrin closed his eyes.

“They were among the last signals we managed to send.”

“Why didn't anyone answer before?”

“Because we had spent so long teaching ourselves not to speak honestly that we no longer knew how to ask for help.”

A deep rumble shook the tower.

The crystal flickered.

Liora looked up.

“The Silence is coming.”

Black letters began appearing along the walls.

Eldrin stepped backwards.

Varun turned to him.

“You know more than you're telling us, don't you?”

The old Keeper stared at the fading crystal.

“Yes,” he whispered. “And it is time you knew the truth.”

# Chapter 9: The Keeper's Secret

Eldrin stood beneath the dying crystal.

“For many years, I protected the messages that travelled through this tower,” he began. “I believed my duty was to prevent confusion and preserve peace.”

He looked at Liora.

“When the rulers began demanding that difficult messages be removed, I obeyed. I told myself that a few forgotten words would not matter.”

“Which messages?” Liora asked.

“Questions about unfair decisions. Stories that challenged the rulers. Complaints from people who felt unheard. Warnings that the kingdom was changing.”

Liora's expression grew cold.

“You destroyed them?”

“Yes.”

The word seemed to echo through the chamber.

Eldrin lowered his head.

“I thought I was protecting Elarion. I believed that if people never heard the arguments, they would never fight. I believed that if everyone received the same approved messages, we would remain united.”

“And instead?” Varun asked.

“Instead, people stopped trusting their own voices. They began hiding their thoughts. They stopped asking questions because they feared what the answers might reveal.”

Eldrin looked at the crystal.

“The tower does not survive on words alone. It survives on the connections between people. Every honest conversation strengthens those connections. Every truth deliberately buried weakens them.”

A black shape moved across the ceiling.

Eldrin continued.

“The messages I destroyed left gaps in the tower. Over time, those gaps gathered the weight of everything people refused to say and hear. That weight became The Silence.”

Liora looked away, hurt and angry.

“You knew what was happening.”

“Not at first. By the time I understood, I was ashamed. I feared admitting what I had done would destroy the last trust people had in me.”

“So you stayed silent again,” Varun said.

Eldrin nodded.

“Yes.”

The tower trembled.

The crystal dimmed until only a tiny spark remained.

Varun looked at the old Keeper.

“Why tell us now?”

“Because I cannot save a world by hiding the truth about how I helped endanger it.”

Liora was silent for a long moment.

“You cannot undo what you did,” she said at last.

“I know.”

“But you can stop hiding it.”

Eldrin looked at her, and something changed in his expression. Not relief. Not forgiveness.

Responsibility.

“Yes,” he said. “I can.”

A wave of black letters rushed through the doorway.

The Silence had arrived.

# Chapter 10: The Last Transmission

The chamber shook as The Silence spread across the tower walls.

Letters twisted into dark shapes, swallowing the remaining messages. The crystal above the platform flickered like a candle in a storm.

Varun ran towards the central console.

“We have to send another message!”

He began typing as quickly as he could.

He tried to explain everything: the tower, the lost memories, the rulers' decisions, Eldrin's confession, and the danger threatening Elarion.

The message appeared on the crystal.

Then vanished.

He tried again, choosing more elegant words and arranging them into a perfect explanation.

The message disappeared a second time.

“Why isn't it working?” he shouted.

The Silence moved closer.

Liora stood beside him.

“Maybe it isn't looking for a perfect message.”

“Then what is it looking for?”

“Something we have forgotten how to give.”

Varun stared at the keyboard.

Keyboard Sai had been unusually quiet.

“Say something,” Varun whispered.

The keys clicked.

```
I DON'T KNOW WHAT TO SAY.
```

Varun blinked.

“You always know what to say.”

```
NO. I JUST PRETEND I DO.
```

Another line appeared.

```
I THOUGHT IF I COULD MAKE EVERYTHING SOUND
CLEVER, NO ONE WOULD NOTICE WHEN I WAS AFRAID.
```

Varun looked at the screen.

For all its jokes and confidence, even Keyboard Sai had been hiding behind words.

“Afraid of what?”

```
OF BEING USELESS.
```

The Silence surged forward.

Varun looked at Liora. He thought about her grandmother's stories, the forgotten names in Auralis, and the people who had been afraid to speak.

He thought about Eldrin, who had made terrible choices because he feared the consequences of telling the truth.

He thought about his own world, where people sometimes cared more about winning an argument than understanding another person.

Perhaps the answer was not a perfect explanation.

Perhaps it was a promise they could actually keep.

Varun placed his hands on the keyboard.

This time, he did not try to sound extraordinary.

He wrote what he meant.

```
WE MAY NOT UNDERSTAND EVERY WORD YOU SAY.

WE MAY MAKE MISTAKES.

WE MAY TAKE A LONG TIME TO ANSWER.

BUT THAT DOESN'T MEAN WE'VE FORGOTTEN YOU.

WE'RE LISTENING.
```

The message appeared above the crystal.

It did not vanish.

For the first time, The Silence stopped moving.

Liora read the words.

Then she turned towards the ancient symbols carved into the tower wall.

“I know this language,” she whispered. “It is older than the kingdom.”

She began translating the message aloud.

Her voice trembled at first. Then it grew stronger.

Eldrin joined her.

Together, they spoke the words into the chamber.

The crystal shone.

And somewhere beyond the tower, someone answered.

# Chapter 11: A Message Without Perfection

The first reply was faint.

It came from somewhere far beyond Elarion, carried through a path that had almost disappeared.

Then another answer followed.

And another.

The tower filled with fragments of voices.

People began sharing memories they had kept hidden. They asked questions they had been afraid to ask. They admitted mistakes. They apologised for words that had caused pain and listened to stories they had once dismissed.

Some disagreed.

Some cried.

Some did not know what to say.

But they stayed.

They listened.

Across Auralis, people gathered in the streets. A woman who had forgotten the boy's name asked him to tell her again. He did, and she repeated it carefully until she remembered.

In the library, the pages stopped fading. Stories once considered dangerous began to glow—not because every story was correct, but because people were finally allowed to examine them, question them, and learn from them.

Eldrin stepped towards the crystal.

He could have remained silent and allowed the kingdom to celebrate without knowing what he had done.

Instead, he spoke.

“I must tell you the truth,” he announced.

The tower carried his voice across Elarion.

“I destroyed messages because I believed that removing disagreement would preserve peace. I was wrong. My decisions weakened the connections that held this tower together. I helped create the conditions that allowed The Silence to grow.”

The chamber became quiet.

Eldrin did not ask for forgiveness.

He did not make excuses.

“I cannot undo the harm I caused,” he continued. “But I will no longer hide it. From this day forward, the tower will not be controlled by a single voice. Its messages must be protected, questioned, and heard—not erased simply because someone finds them uncomfortable.”

Liora watched him.

She was not ready to forgive everything.

But she could see that, for the first time, Eldrin was taking responsibility without hiding behind fear.

The crystal grew brighter.

The black letters covering the walls began to separate. Their sharp edges softened, and their shapes changed into tiny points of light.

The Silence did not explode.

It did not scream.

It simply began to dissolve.

For centuries, the people of Elarion had imagined that their greatest enemy would be a monster they could defeat.

They had never understood that some darkness grows when people refuse to face what they have done.

Now they were beginning to understand.

The tower shone brighter than it had in generations.

And across the paths between worlds, the messages continued.

Not perfect messages.

Honest ones.

# Chapter 12: The Light That Answered

When the final shadow disappeared, silence returned to the tower.

But this time, it was peaceful.

The crystal above the platform shone with a warm golden light. Its brightness spread through the walls, illuminating every inscription and every forgotten message.

Liora stood beside Varun.

“It's beautiful,” she whispered.

Varun smiled.

“Your tower has excellent lighting.”

She laughed.

It was the first time he had heard her laugh without fear hiding behind it.

Eldrin approached them.

“I owe you both more than I can express.”

“You owe Elarion the truth,” Liora replied. “And the work of rebuilding what was lost.”

Eldrin nodded.

“I will begin today.”

Varun looked towards the doorway through which he had entered this strange world.

“Does this mean I can go home?”

Liora's smile faded slightly.

“Yes.”

“Will we ever speak again?”

“The paths are open. I cannot promise when another message will reach you, but the connection is alive.”

She placed a small crystal in his hand.

It glowed softly.

“Keep this. If the light ever begins to fade, it may help you remember what happened here.”

Varun closed his fingers around it.

“I don't think I'll forget.”

The golden doorway appeared.

Before stepping through, Varun turned back.

“Liora?”

“Yes?”

“Thank you for trusting a stranger.”

She looked at the restored tower.

“Thank you for answering.”

Varun stepped through the doorway and returned to his room.

His computer sat exactly where he had left it. The clock had barely moved.

For a moment, he wondered whether the entire adventure had been a dream.

Then the crystal in his hand glowed.

The keyboard clicked.

A message appeared on the screen.

```
DEAR VARUN, THANK YOU FOR LISTENING.
```

Varun smiled.

Then another line appeared.

```
P.S. I EXPECT FULL CO-AUTHOR CREDIT.
```

Varun laughed so loudly that someone in the next room called to ask what was happening.

“Nothing!” he replied. “Just finishing a story!”

He opened a new document.

At the top of the page, he typed a title.

The Unknown Signal.

He wrote about a kingdom that had almost forgotten itself, a girl who protected stories, an old Keeper who learned to confess his mistakes, and a darkness that weakened when people finally listened.

He wrote about the message that saved Elarion.

And he wrote about the truth he had discovered along the way.

Words did not need to be perfect to matter.

They needed honesty, courage, and someone willing to listen.

Far away, in a kingdom beneath a sky filled with floating islands, Liora stood beside the Tower of First Words.

Its golden light reached into the distance.

A tiny signal travelled along the paths between worlds.

And somewhere on Earth, a young writer answered by continuing to write.

# THE END

# The Moral of the Story

You don't need perfect words to make a meaningful connection. You need the courage to speak honestly and the willingness to listen.

The world does not become better because everyone thinks alike. It becomes better when people can disagree without silencing one another, admit mistakes without losing hope, and try to understand what they do not yet know.

Sometimes, a single honest message can begin a change that thousands of perfect words never could.